Managing Anxiety and Encouraging Multisport Participation

From R. Martens and R.S. Vealey, *Successful Coaching*, 5th ed. (Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics, 2024), 94-99.

Arousal is a state of physical and mental energy or readiness. It's a mistake to think that "more is better" when it comes to arousal and its effect on performance. Instead, there is an optimal level of arousal for performing well, as shown in figure 6.2. When athletes have too low or too high a level of arousal, they do not perform as well as they might; but if their arousal level is just right, their performance will be better.

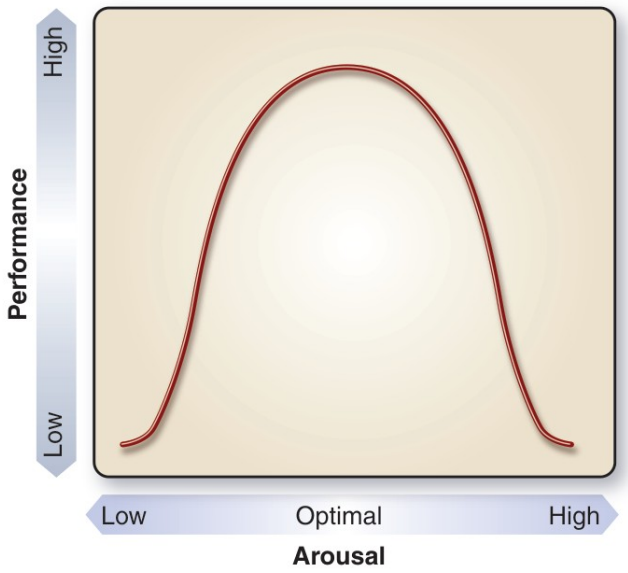


FIGURE 6.2 The inverted-U relationship between arousal and performance.

The optimal arousal level varies for different sport skills. As shown in figure 6.3, high-precision sport skills requiring fine motor control such as golf putting, shooting, and bowling are best performed with lower levels of arousal. Sports such as basketball, baseball, and volleyball are played better at slightly higher levels of arousal, and skills requiring the highest levels of intensity such as tackling and blocking in football and weightlifting are best done with high levels of arousal. Optimal arousal levels also differ from athlete to athlete. One athlete may perform a sport skill better with considerably less arousal than another athlete may need to perform well.

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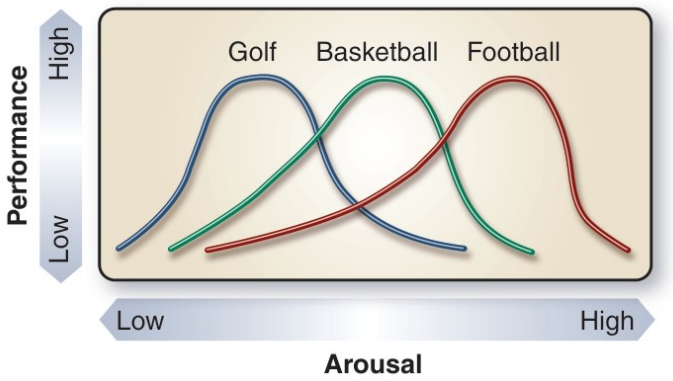


FIGURE 6.3 Optimal arousal levels for performance in different sports.

COACHING YOURSELF: MANAGING YOUR EMOTIONS

Just like athletes, coaches must manage their emotions to perform effectively. Your personal example of managing your anxiety is a powerful model for your athletes. It's critical to appear poised and in control so that athletes feel reassured when something unexpected occurs. A good image is to think of yourself as the eye of the hurricane, or someone who is challenged but not anxious as the storm swirls around you (Chroni et al., 2016). Sometimes this involves some acting to be outwardly poised and confident when your stomach is churning.



Emotion can interfere with your decision making and communication with athletes. Anxiety makes some coaches talk too much and overcoach, while for others, it can make them go quiet and stop coaching. Unmanaged anger can lead to embarrassing behaviors and even expulsion from competition. What are your emotional tendencies in competition? What are some strategies you can use to be more effective when these emotions arise? Here are some suggestions:

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COACHING YOURSELF: MANAGING YOUR EMOTIONS *(continued)*

- Mentally prepare productive responses to situations that trigger your emotions. A basketball coach described using this strategy (Bloom et al., 1997, p. 133):

  My biggest problem is emotional control during games, so I have to mentally rehearse all the situations and decide in advance how I am going to react. When I see who is officiating... I visualize those people making the usual screwups that they make and how I am going to react. I have to do that or I would be out of control.

- Mentally rehearse who you are at your best when coaching, and arrive at the competitive site as that person.
- Plan some simple strategies to use during competition to help manage your emotions. You could use a deep breath and shoulder shrug for a quick relaxation response and follow that with a go-to phrase to redirect your focus (e.g., "coach the game").
- Arrange to be video-recorded while you coach and study the video to evaluate your poise and nonverbal messages during competition.
- Ask a trusted assistant coach or someone close to your program to provide you honest feedback about your coaching in pressure situations.
- Remember your controllable goals as a coach (versus uncontrollable goals) as well as your coaching philosophy and objectives in which the development and well-being of your athletes are of highest priority.

Helping Athletes Manage Their Anxiety

If some arousal is good, why isn't more of it better? High levels of arousal usually occur when athletes become anxious and worried about whether they will be able to succeed—especially failure-oriented athletes. Anxiety is based on the threat of failure and being evaluated by others in the very public arena of sport. Athletes are often uncertain if they can meet the demands and perform well, especially in situations where the outcome is very important (e.g., championship competition).

Anxiety hurts performance in two ways. First, it causes muscles to tense so that athletes' movements are not as smooth and easy as when their muscles are more relaxed. Second, anxiety disrupts the focus needed to perform well. It can cause athletes to think about how they are doing a skill rather than concentrating on just doing it (as the famous Nike tagline reminds us). Anxious thinking is typically future oriented and involves worries about outcomes, which disrupts athletes' optimal focus on task-relevant cues.

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How can we help athletes manage their anxiety? Several strategies are suggested here for coaches:

1. *Decrease athletes' feelings of uncertainty.* Coaches can emphasize that athletes and the team as a whole are ready and well-prepared leading into competition. They can remind athletes that all they need to do is play and compete like they do each day in practice. At halftime of a national championship game, Alabama football coach Nick Saban (2007) reminded his team, "All we've got to be is us."
2. *Teach athletes that anxiety, which may feel unpleasant, can be a helpful response to get their bodies ready to compete.* Our bodies are biochemical wonders that prepare us to exert great effort and intensity to perform amazing feats. Anxiety can be a helpful mental and physical response that enables athletes to perform at higher levels (Hanton et al., 2008).

   Whether anxiety helps or hurts performance is largely determined by how athletes interpret their anxiety symptoms. If athletes feel anxious and think of that as a harmful thing, they tend to shift their attention to the threatening aspects of competition (e.g., how I might screw up, what could go wrong, I'll let others down). However, mentally skilled athletes perceive anxiety as a signal to engage in coping and focus strategies to productively manage their thoughts and feelings (Hanton et al., 2008). Athletes should think about using the energy versus allowing the energy to use them. Tiger Woods explained how he views his anxiety (Morrice 2019, p. 58):

   > *Am I ever nervous? Are you kidding me? I'm nervous on the very first shot. I'm nervous throughout the entire day. But it's how I channel it, how I harness it. How do I put that energy into deeper focus or deeper intensity? That's something we all can do. It's not being afraid of it or ashamed of it. Go after it.*

   Teach athletes to accept the anxiety that is a normal response to competition, and to use the feelings as a sign of readiness and excitement.

3. *Provide athletes with some strategies to use when they feel anxious.* Athletes should focus on controllable process goals to keep their focus on the task (e.g., "next play" or "solid"). Instead of thinking, "I'm nervous," they should think, "I'm excited" or "I'm ready." Deep breaths help our bodies to relax, and a strong posture and confident walk helps us to feel more in control. Athletes should plan and then stick to preperformance routines to prime themselves in a familiar way for performance. These are preplanned ways of preparing for competition—doing certain things and thinking in productive ways. For some athletes, being distracted from the upcoming competition (and thinking too much), such as hanging out with teammates, is helpful.

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Burnout

Just as too much motivation can lead to over-arousal and anxiety, it can also lead to burnout. Burnout is a negative psychological and physical state in which athletes feel tired, less able to perform well, and less interested in their sport. In extreme cases of burnout, athletes also may drop out of the sport they once loved and played with vigor (Isoard-Gautheur et al., 2016).

There's no one reason why athletes experience burnout in sport. Rather, there is a multitude of factors that seem to add up and lead to burnout. Athletes who are perfectionistic, obsessed with their sport, and base their feelings of self-worth on their performance are candidates for burnout (Martin & Horn, 2013). In addition, athletes who narrowly specialize in one sport at an early age put all their eggs in one basket and are at risk for undue pressure and burnout based on their narrow identity development.

Burnout occurs due to excessive training often without adequate recovery. To top it off, athletes are participating in a highly controlled environment where there is pressure to perform from parents, guardians, and coaches. Athletes experiencing burnout have described feeling trapped in their sport as compared to athletes who are personally invested in and enthusiastic about participating (Holmberg & Sheridan, 2013).

In this age of intense technical training, coaches need to ensure that athletes, even at young ages, receive adequate rest and recovery. Athletes also need mental rejuvenation at times, such as an unexpected day off or a fun activity in practice conducted in a lighthearted way. Coaches should seek innovative ways of training athletes that vary enough to enhance motivation and avoid staleness. Focus on the quality of training athletes receive within reasonable practice time frames.

Help perfectionistic athletes learn to accept mistakes and move on; help them set appropriate personal performance goals to avoid overtraining. Athletes who lack passion —or love of playing—are ripe for burnout because they're playing for the wrong reasons and may feel trapped in their participation. Ask questions such as: How do you feel about playing? What would make you enjoy playing more?

Is It Wise to Specialize?

Over the past three decades, a popular idea has emerged that young athletes should specialize early in one sport to enhance their chances of attaining elite status in that sport (e.g., earning a college scholarship). Does sport specialization meet the motivational needs of young athletes? You could argue that it could build their competence in a sport by focusing technical training specifically on that one sport, but does specialization meet athletes' needs for fun and stimulation, as well as autonomy? Are athletes motivated to specialize in one sport, or are they being forced into specialization only to burn out or lose interest due to the intense focus on one activity? The answer is: It depends.

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Some kids fall in love with a sport and choose to focus all their attention on that sport. Sidney Crosby grew up as a hockey phenom in eastern Canada, and chose to relentlessly practice and play only hockey as a child. Professional tennis players Serena and Venus Williams grew up focused on tennis and training with their father on public courts in southern California. Clearly, there are athletes who choose to specialize early because the sport is their passion. The problem is that adults see these examples and assume that early, exclusive specialization is the path that all kids should take.

There is another path. Consider this list of athletes who played multiple sports growing up: Tom Brady, Patrick Mahomes, Abby Wambach, Jordan Spieth, and Rafael Nadal. Many athletes would prefer to play more than one sport, so why force them to choose? We tend to forget that the motivation must be inside the athletes, and that to specialize must be their choice. Many teenagers would rather participate in multiple sports, and there are advantages to this.

Many adults uncritically accept the idea that specialization is the way to go, even though only 2 percent of all high school athletes will gain college athletic scholarships. As a coach, your leadership and guidance as to whether kids should specialize or not is important.

Merits of Early Diversification

Research has shown that elite athletes typically played multiple sports at a young age and did not narrow their focus onto one sport until around age 13 (MacNamara et al., 2010). A study of over 700 professional baseball players found that their average age of specializing in baseball was 15 years, and the majority didn't specialize until at least 17 years of age (Ginsburg et al., 2014).

Early diversification develops a broad range of skills and different sport experiences that provide athletes with more athleticism if they choose to specialize in one sport later. You probably have observed a highly specialized athlete who could perform the mechanics of his sport but lacked well-rounded motor skills. We've heard basketball coaches speak of the inability of a player to throw an overhand baseball pass, or a middle hitter in volleyball who lacks an effective arm swing because she never played softball or grew up playing catch. Abby Wambach, former U.S. soccer star, explained the advantage she gained in diversifying her experience: "Playing basketball had a significant impact on the way I play soccer. Learning the timing of your jump, and the trajectory of the ball coming off the rim. It's the same game as soccer, in terms of vision" (Rogers, 2015).

Early specialization has been linked to dropping out and burnout out of sport (Fraser-Thomas et al., 2008; Wall & Cote, 2007). Wambach goes on to explain how participation in multiple sports gave her a motivational recharge: "I would have burned out as a young kid playing only one sport. Playing basketball gave me the chance to crave soccer, to miss it" (Rogers, 2015). UCLA baseball coach John Savage explained his preference for

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multiple sport athletes: “We like ’em cross-trained. Stick with multiple sports as long as you possibly can, and people are going to see your tools. Stick with one sport long enough, and people are going to see your scars” (Matz, 2014).



Early on, Abby Wambach played basketball along with soccer, which allowed her to excel in her signature sport of soccer later in life.

DANIEL ROLAND/AFP via Getty Images

Most Sports Don’t Require Early Specialization

Early specialization is not required for expertise in most sports. More complex sports that require highly developed muscle control and coordination require earlier practice (e.g., starting at five to seven years, specializing at about age nine) if athletes seek to attain elite status (Balyi et al., 2013). These early specialization sports include gymnastics, diving, and figure skating. Highly kinesthetic (awareness of body position or “feel”) sports have also been suggested as requiring early specialization, including equestrian events and swimming. Specialization in all other sports doesn’t need to occur until ages 14 to 16.

Some sports that are considered as late specialization require some “early engagement,” or beginning participation by age eight to gain the needed “feel,” visual tracking, and perceptual decision making needed in those sports (Balyi et al., 2013). Early engagement by age eight advantages skiers in kinesthetic awareness, hockey players in skating kinesthetics and visual tracking of the puck, and tennis players in visuomotor tracking and eye–hand coordination. However, early engagement just means sampling these sports but not having to exclusively specialize in them.

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Recommendations for Coaches Related to Sport Specialization

1. Prioritize each athlete's development and interests ahead of your own coaching desire to have athletes play your sport year-round. Athletes should not be told that they have to play a sport year-round, even in high school. It should be each athlete's choice as to whether and when to specialize.
2. Avoid early position specialization within sports. Maturation often changes the sizes and shapes of athletes, so it really makes no sense to pigeon-hole athletes into specific positions when they are young. Well, it does make sense if your objective to win is more important than the overall development of your athletes. Former U.S. national soccer team goalkeepers Hope Solo and Tim Howard played forward and midfield respectively as youth athletes. Both Solo and Howard commented that their early experiences in these positions helped them later as goalies.
3. Remember that the vast majority of middle school and high school athletes will not become elite athletes nor even play in college. Let's help educate parents so that kids can get off the specialization train to nowhere. The cherished days of playing two or three sports in high school and enjoying the changes in activities and different groups of teammates should be reconsidered as a move away from burnout and inappropriate expectations for young athletes.

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